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**rundhati
Bhattacharya
broke the
mould when
she became
India's top
banker, as**

the first woman Chairman of the State Bank of India. Yet, that was not to be the summit of an illustrious career in banking, as she quickly followed that up with an intriguing assignment—as Chairperson and CEO of Salesforce India. In a wide-ranging chat with *Business Today's* Global Business Editor *Udayan Mukherjee*, she discusses her career trajectory, what it takes to reach the top in a male-dominated industry, and the key differences between the Indian public and private sector from her unique vantage point. Edited excerpts:

Q: From State Bank of India to Salesforce India is such a big leap. Were you not daunted by what you were getting yourself into?

A: Well, not daunted really, but a few of my friends did think I was a little crazy and kept questioning why I wanted to do something like this, take such a big risk. Because, you know Udayan, when you take on something that is so different from what you've done for 40 long years, it entails a lot of change. It means learning a lot of things and the chances of success are always 50-50... So I did think about it a lot, but then I had always been very interested in technology and there was not a single technology vendor at SBI that I did not interact with during my tenure. I knew in my bones that going forward, the whole world is going to need digital and every business will need a very strong technology backbone in order to survive... When I got [this] offer, it was like a ringside seat to cutting-edge technology.

Also, during that one year of gardening leave that we are required to take after you retire from the bank, I had been talking a lot to younger generations. And most of them asked me, 'what's our future going to be like?' And I told them, it's not going to be the same as mine... you'll have multiple careers and you need to be able to unlearn, relearn, keep learning all the time. So, when I got the Salesforce opportunity, I told myself that I've been

giving a lot of *gyaan*, a lot of advice. Here was a chance to do it myself, to have multiple careers. And finally, [Chairman, Co-CEO and Co-founder] Marc Benioff had invited me to the Salesforce headquarters because he could see I was still a little unsure... and while coming back he gave me a book called *Trailblazer*. There were two stories I read on the flight back, and they both touched me. One was regarding Marc and Salesforce lobbying to pay more municipal taxes as that would cure the problem of homelessness. Till date, I don't know of a single company that wants to pay taxes, and definitely not one that wants to pay *more* taxes. That impressed me. And the second one was regarding equality where he talks about how he ordered an audit to check that there was no gender pay gap in the company. His HR department told him that once they look into it, and find a gap, Marc would have to cough up more money. He said go right ahead, and Salesforce ended up paying about \$5 million to correct that gap at that point of time. Till date, they have spent about \$16.2 million... These were two things that made me think that this could be an organisation that would give me a lot of added value, and that's the reason I made the jump.

Q: It must be refreshing to be called Chairperson, from being the SBI *Chairman* because they never called you chairperson there, did they?

A: That's right! Actually, I did get my first cards printed as Chairperson, SBI, and promptly got a note from the

“At the core of it all, they [the public sector and the private sector] are very similar. However, there are some grave dissimilarities [between them] as well”

legal department informing me this will not do because the statute that created the State Bank of India does not have the designation of chairperson. And in many cases, where I have to file, for instance, reports, etc., the statute has to come up to show that I have the powers to do this... They said either you go for a change of the Act, but till the change comes through you will be known as Chairman. So I scrapped the cards thinking I had far larger battles to fight at that point. I accepted the term Chairman and went on with it.